
The dark reasons behind all the Richard Nixon worship

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The dark reasons behind all the Richard Nixon worship

I suppose a Richard Nixon revival was inevitable. After all, the 37th president was the modern model of the corrupt, abusive presidency that is currently being perfected by [Donald Trump](#) and his corrupt administration. In fact, much of the legal theory of the [unitary executive](#) under which the current administration operates sprang from the bowels of right-wing think tanks smarting from Nixon's fall from grace.

Many of the norms, rules and laws that governed the executive branch until Trump and his loyalists systematically threw them in the White House dumpster originated in the aftermath of Watergate, so reimagining Nixon as the first victim of the so-called deep state serves as a perfect rationale for what is happening today. For conservatives, the long-awaited historical payback has finally come.

In July, the Wall Street Journal [reported](#) that Nixon is suddenly all the rage among young conservatives who are "Nixonmaxxing" all over social media and sporting merch with sayings like "Nixon now, more than ever" and "Pretty girls for Nixon." One young fan mused, "Is Nixon pulling off the greatest posthumous political comeback in history?"

Maybe so. This new interest among the Gen Z crowd is actually a well-designed public relations campaign by The Nixon Foundation, which used social media in 2018 to celebrate the 50th anniversary of his presidency. Short-form videos featuring Nixon saying "I am not a crook" over gangster rap, along with clips from "Mad Men" showing Jon Hamm-as-Don Draper saying, "Kennedy, I see a silver spoon, Nixon, I see myself," went viral.

But the fandom is more than just vibes. Podcasters like Joe Rogan and Tucker Carlson have both recently called Watergate a setup, never mind the evidence or admissions by Nixon's accomplices like H.R. Haldeman in his diary. Even Vice President JD Vance is in on the act, comparing himself to Nixon in June during an event to promote his memoir at the Richard Nixon Presidential Library and Museum: "Young senator, vice president, writes some bestselling books, is hated by the media." (He's not wrong.)

"I've always liked Richard Nixon," Vance said, calling him a political genius. The vice president praised Nixon's foreign policy acumen, giving him props for the opening of China and the Vietnam peace process, while conveniently leaving out the part about bombing Cambodia. Vance also denigrated the Watergate hearings and investigations that eventually brought Nixon down, saying, "If Watergate happened tomorrow, it would be a 12-hour news story. The idea that it would have taken down a presidency is crazy."

Nixon didn't have the right-wing media machinery that now excuses Trump's criminality and spreads conspiracy theories — like the trope that the "deep state" is out to get the president. That alone has managed to keep the MAGA base and Republican officials on board with Trump.

Sadly, he's probably right. Nixon didn't have the right-wing media machinery that now excuses Trump's criminality and spreads conspiracy theories — like the trope that the "deep state" is out to get the president. That alone has managed to keep the MAGA base and Republican officials on board with Trump, which is why he was acquitted in two impeachment trials during his first term. After all, Nixon didn't resign until he was told that he had lost his base in the Senate and faced certain conviction and removal from office. That wasn't the case in February 2021, of course, when

the Senate refused to convict Trump for “[Incitement of Insurrection](#).”

But there is also evidence that even Nixon had his limits. Yes, he grossly abused the office of the presidency, treating the executive branch like his private fiefdom. He ordered the FBI and the CIA to commit crimes. He bribed, blackmailed and paid off potential witnesses against him. But he didn't burn the tapes, and he dutifully turned them over when the Supreme Court ordered him to do so. And although there was that infamous “19-minute gap” on one of the tapes that would have sealed his fate, many of the conversations revealed a profane, corrupt president.

But even as Nixon's overall approval rating [sank to 24%](#) during the week before his resignation on Aug. 9, 1974, Republicans — 62% of them — still supported him. These were undoubtedly some of the die-hards who eventually began pushing to roll back the reforms that were enacted in Nixon's wake.

During a post-presidency with British television presenter David Frost, Nixon famously said, “When the president does it, it's not illegal.” Those words sounded then — and sound now — like an authoritarian gaffe. But in reality, the idea was based on a very real concept popular among right-wing Republicans, who believed that the president should have unfettered power to enact policies to “protect” the nation.

After that interview, Nixon [penned a 2,500-word essay](#) explaining he didn't believe the president is above the law, but that the nation's executive must be granted “some faith in his judgment” and given “room for maneuver.”

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“His powers are not unlimited,” Nixon wrote. “But neither can be existing law — in a limited way, and at times of special need — and still meet these larger responsibilities.” Apparently, “special need” could be defined as whatever the president says it is, and therein lies the unlimited power.

This notion forms much of the logic of the unitary executive theory that has been growing among thinkers on the right for decades, and with court cases beginning in the early 1980s, the presidency has been granted more and more such power. This, of course, culminated in Trump v. United States, the 2024 Supreme Court ruling that gave the president near total immunity from prosecution for anything done in office. (The president had already been granted immunity from civil liability by the Court in Nixon v. Fitzgerald in 1982.) Now, the idea that presidents are above the law is gaining steam with yet another “investigation of the investigation,” this time into the special prosecutors who scrutinized Nixon back in 1974.

The Wall Street Journal [reports](#) that the Trump Justice Department is now officially looking into that case based upon the conspiracy theories promulgated by Geoff Shepard, a former Nixon aide turned historical revisionist and conspiracy theorist who presented “a two-hour presentation at Justice Department headquarters called ‘Watergate As Lawfare,’” making the argument that, you guessed it, the deep state took down Richard Nixon.

There's a method to all this madness, and it's best illustrated by the fact that Vance is the one leading the charge. Any ambitious Republican official thinking about the future has to find some way to excuse their complicity in Trump's corrupt — and likely illegal — behavior. If they have any hope of

being elected to national office, their only choice is to try to maintain these MAGA fictions and arcane conspiracy theories after Trump is gone by continuing to deny the reality of what he's done. One way to do that is to convince people that it was never just about Trump; the deep state has been out to get Republicans ever since Nixon.

If they can't convince people that their complicity was actually righteous resistance to a secret cabal of bureaucrats and dirty cops fighting to keep Republicans from enacting their righteous agenda, then potential GOP presidential candidates like Vance are likely going to have a hard time overcoming what is likely to be a massive revolt against Trumpism once he is out of office.

We're seeing the edge of it now — and it's not just about the price of gas. The air is finally going out of MAGA, and every single Republican politician who took advantage of it will be held accountable by the voters for what they have done. The GOP's only hope is to find a Republican somewhere who hasn't been touched by Trump and MAGA.

Good luck with that.

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